

starts פרשת תולדות (25:19), and then we immediately go into the story of the birth of יעקב and עשו. We see that עשו is described as אִישׁ יָדַע צֵיד אִישׁ שָׂדֶה (25:27), and יעקב as אִישׁ תָּם יֹשֵׁב אֲהָלִים (25:27).

מי שְׁאִינוּ חָרִיף gives us a fantastic insight here. It seems so simple and yet it's so profound: חָרִיף - "A person who is not quick and unable to deceive others is called a תָּם".

It's an interesting word choice. We often interpret תָּם as meaning innocent or simple, but רש"י highlights a different angle here, suggesting it also implies a lack of cunning. There's a powerful lesson in this approach, as brought down in the מורה נבוכים quoting הרבי הקדוש מלובלין on this רש"י. The idea is that a person has an obligation to hold his מידות in his hand and be מושל on them, to control them and use them as needed. Sometimes, even a מידה רעה can be used לשם שמים.

As רבי שמואל בר יוחנן אומר, כָּל מִי שֶׁנִּצְעָצַע רַחֲמָנָא בְּמָקוֹם אֲכִזְרִי, סוֹף שֶׁנִּצְעָצַע: (7:16) קהלת רבה teach us in חז"ל - "If someone shows רחמנות where they should be strict, they may end up being אכזרי where they should show compassion". The classic example is שאול המלך, who showed רחמנות to עמלק, but later wiped out the entire city of גֹּב.

So it's not the מידה of רחמנות itself that's important. It's how and when one uses it. רש"י is telling us that מי שְׁאִינוּ חָרִיף לְרַמּוֹת is called a תָּם. This concept of תָּם, interestingly enough, shows up in פסח on ארבעה בנים. Often, we picture the תָּם as a sweet, innocent child. But in תנ"ך and literature, תָּם can mean someone who is simple in a naive sense, someone who doesn't know how to navigate complex or crafty situations.

However, the תורה doesn't call יעקב a תָּם; it calls him an אִישׁ תָּם. That detail is significant. רש"י says, "מי שְׁאִינוּ חָרִיף לְרַמּוֹת," someone who isn't quick to deceive, is a תָּם. But יעקב is described as an אִישׁ תָּם - an אִישׁ who was master of his תמימות, who knew when to use it and when to restrain it.

As the פסוק says in תהילים (18:27): וְעַם עֲקֹשׁ תִּתְּפַחַל, and as it also says in the מדרש (29:12) (ע"ש רש"י) could be slick when necessary. This is what רש"י means: someone who cannot control himself, who is always a תָּם and thus easily taken advantage of, is not an אִישׁ תָּם. But יעקב אבינו could use חריפות and רמאות when the situation called for it, as we see in his dealings with עשו and לבן.

This brings a crucial מוסר השכל for us: we must control and channel all of our מידות. A person who has a tendency towards arrogance or anger must control and redirect those traits. Similarly, someone who is תָּם by nature, who is trusting and easily believes others, must know when to temper that nature.

We must be the masters of our own מידות. There's no concept in Judaism like "temporary insanity" as an excuse; we are responsible to maintain control and use what we've been given לשם שמים and for עבודה ה'. Bezras Hashem, may we succeed in improving ourselves and our עבודה and reach true שלמות.

